

Goal

We develop a carefully controlled experimental paradigm, motivated by issues in semantic fieldwork, to probe how varied morphosyntactic strategies express comparison.

BACKGROUND AND DESIGN

- Expressions of comparison differ greatly in their morphosyntactic and semantic properties, both across languages and within a given language.
- Can differ in terms of the morphological components that encode comparison or semantic type of the gradable predicate
- A crucial point of cross-linguistic variation proposed by the Degree Semantics Parameter is whether or not a gradable predicate introduces a degree argument (Beck et al., 2009).
- Languages like Washo, Nez Perce, and more recently ASL have been argued to be “degree-less” languages. (Bochnak, 2015; Deal and Hohaus, 2019; Koulidobrova et al 2023)

- Claims about universality or variation in these domains depend on consistent data collection methodologies.** We develop a paradigm inspired by fieldwork methodology that can be implemented cross-linguistically, and across modalities.

- Based on theoretically relevant contrasts, we test our paradigm to investigate the semantic *signatures* of four strategies in English.

1. Emani is taller than Theodore. [EXPLICIT]
2. Emani is tall compared to Theodore. [IMPLICIT]
3. Theodore is tall, Emani is very tall. [INTENSIFICATION]
4. Theodore is tall Emani is tall [GESTURE]



- For each strategy, our design evaluates the following factors:
 - “Crisp judgment” contexts with minimal differences between comparands, a crucial diagnostic for explicit comparatives such as the English -er strategy. (Kennedy 2007)

- Entailment of the positive form of the adjective, critical cue for how to build semantics from gradable predicate (Castillo-Gamboa et al. 2021)

- The ability to infer comparison expressed via iconic elements such as co-speech gesture. (Aristodemou and Geraci 2018; Koulidobrova et al 2023).

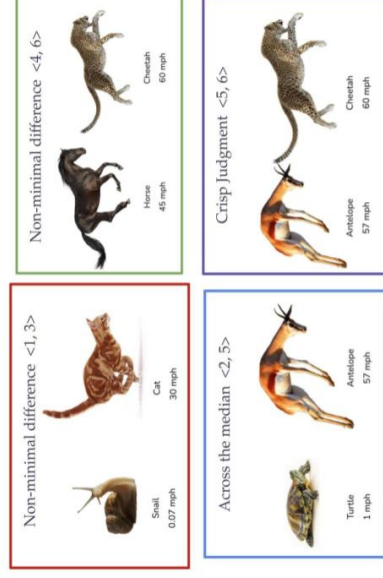
- We test each expression across six **Adjectival Scales**



Signatures of Comparison

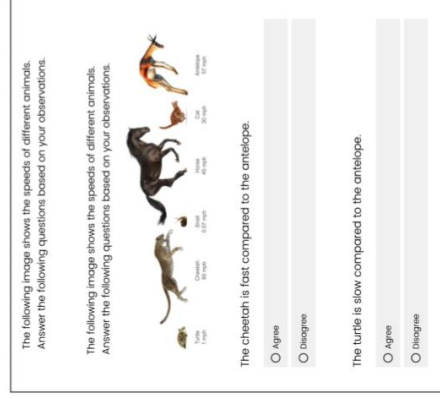
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- Each scale of measurement (height, width, weight, speed, temperature, age) maps to a pair of relative gradable predicates. We also balance the iconic potential of the predicate.



- Theoretically relevant contrasts probed across four Comparison Contexts:

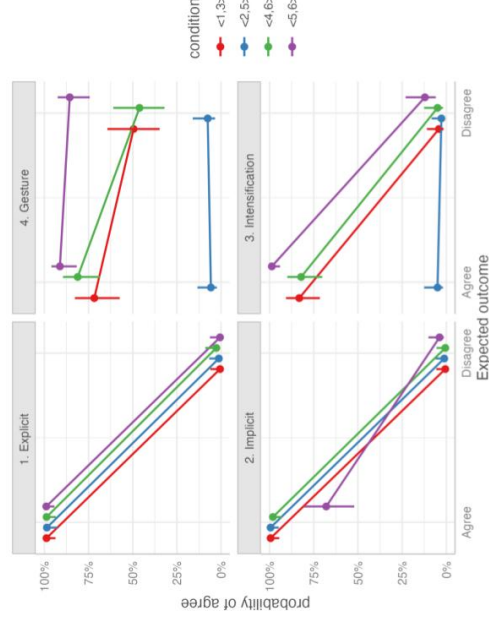
- Non-minimal differences provide baselines at low <1,3> and high values <4,6> to generalize to both ends of the gradable scale.
- Minimal difference <5,6> tests crisp judgment contexts
- Across the median <2,5> tests entailment of the positive form.



Procedure:

- Participants evaluated pairs of sentences relative to visual stimuli in a binary judgment task implemented via Qualtrics
- Total 120 native English speakers recruited via Prolific
- Latin square crossing four strategies and four comparison context across six adjectival scales
- Three strategies were presented as written text; gesture comparatives as videos

RESULTS BY STRATEGY



Effect of iconicity for gesture comparatives

Iconic (Gesture, but looking ahead: equivalents of these in ASL are highly depictive)



Non-Iconic (Gesture, but looking ahead: equivalents in ASL predicates are not depictive)



Takeaways

Our paradigm captures the semantic signatures of known variation across multiple expressions of comparison, including (a) the difference in crisp judgments between explicit and implicit comparatives and (b) the requirement that intensification entails the positive form of the adjective

It also extends our knowledge even for English: we uncover new insights such as the seeming crisp-judgements for intensification, and iconicity in gesture comparatives

Finally, it provides a paradigm for probing the semantics of new expressions of comparison that can be used in the context of understudied languages, including across modalities